



Prof. Dr.-Ing. Lamyia Abdullah

Interkulturelle Kommunikation und heterogene Teams.
LectureNotes 03 Culture 2.0

More About

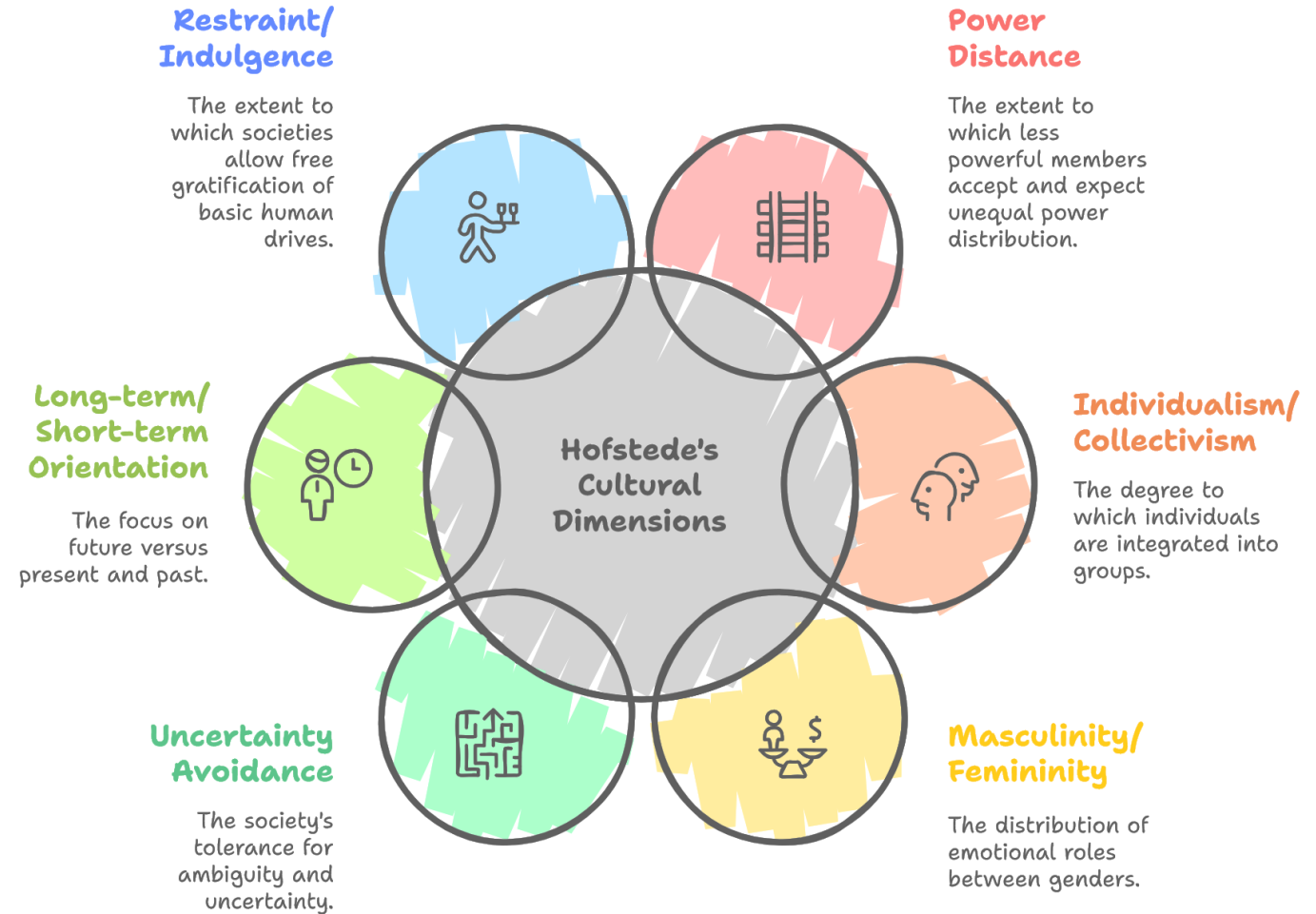


Hofstede Framework – review

Hofstede = “How cultures differ at national level”

- Power distance → hierarchy vs equality
- Individualism → “I” vs “We”
- Uncertainty → structure vs flexibility

Hofstede's Cultural Framework



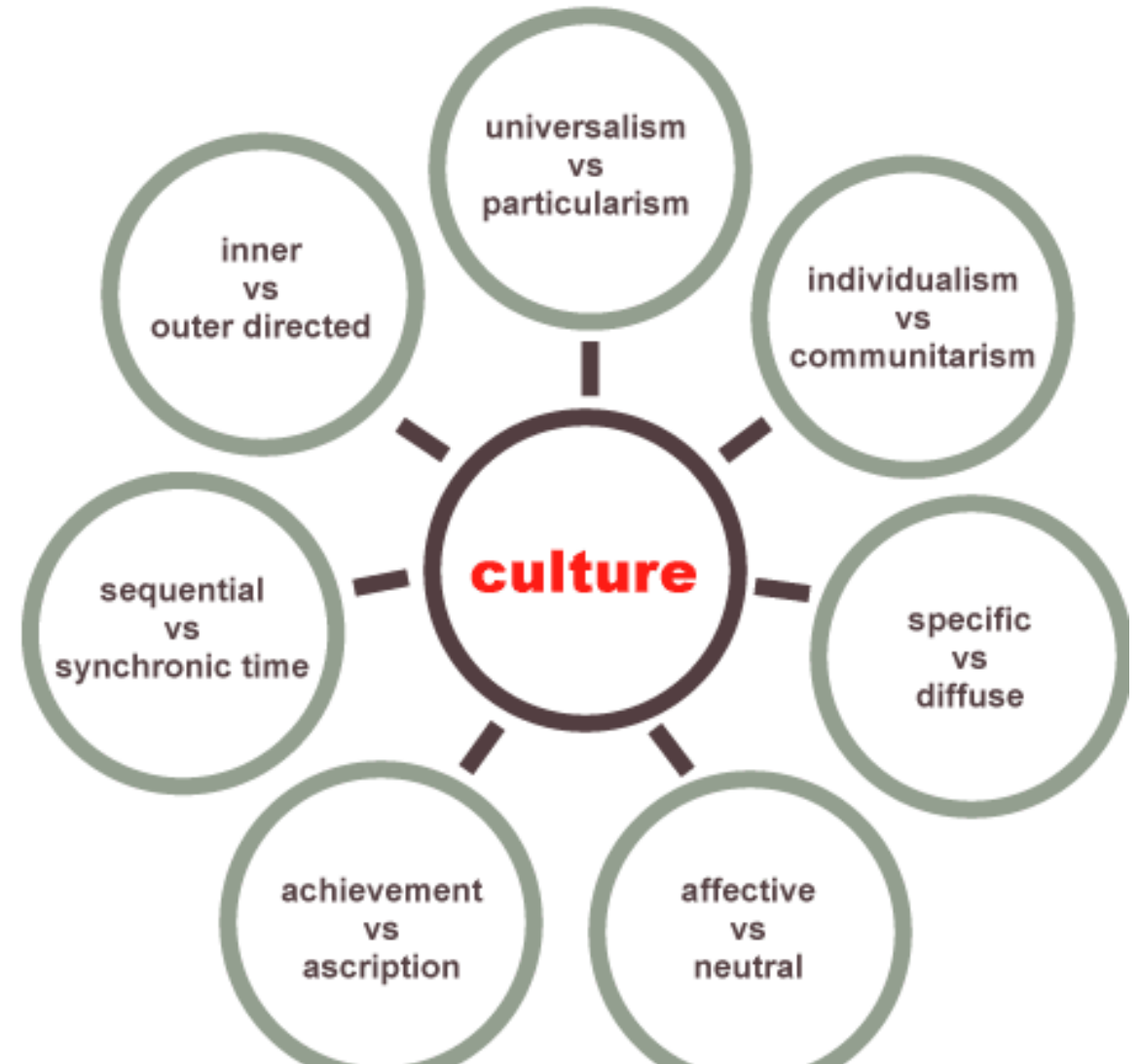
A low-angle, blue-tinted photograph of a group of graduates in black gowns. They are all looking upwards with expressions of joy and excitement, and several black graduation caps are captured mid-air, having been tossed by the graduates. The background is a bright, clear sky.

Trompenaars Cultural Dimensions (Overview)

Trompenaars Model: Understanding Cultural Differences

Cultures differ in how people **relate to rules**, **relationships**, and **emotions**.

“Do people follow rules or relationships?”



Key Dimensions (simplified)

Dimension	Key Question	Example
Universalism vs Particularism	Rules or relationships?	Do people follow rules strictly or adapt based on relationships?
Individualism vs Communitarianism	“I” or “We”?	Focus on personal goals vs group goals
Neutral vs Emotional	Show emotions or not?	Are emotions controlled or openly expressed?
Specific vs Diffuse	Separate or mix life?	Do people separate work & private life, or mix them?

Universalist cultures → **rules apply equally**

Particularist cultures → **relationships matter more than rules**

How Trompenaars Explains Workplace Behaviour

Real-Life Examples

Application: Culture in Practice

Situation	Universalism	Particularism
Deadlines	Must always be respected	Flexible if relationship matters
Contracts	Strict, formal	Can adapt based on trust

Meetings	Calm, controlled	Expressive, animated
Feedback	Formal, structured	Direct, emotional

Most **conflicts** in teams happen because:
One side expects **rules**
The other expects **relationships**

Self-reflection ...

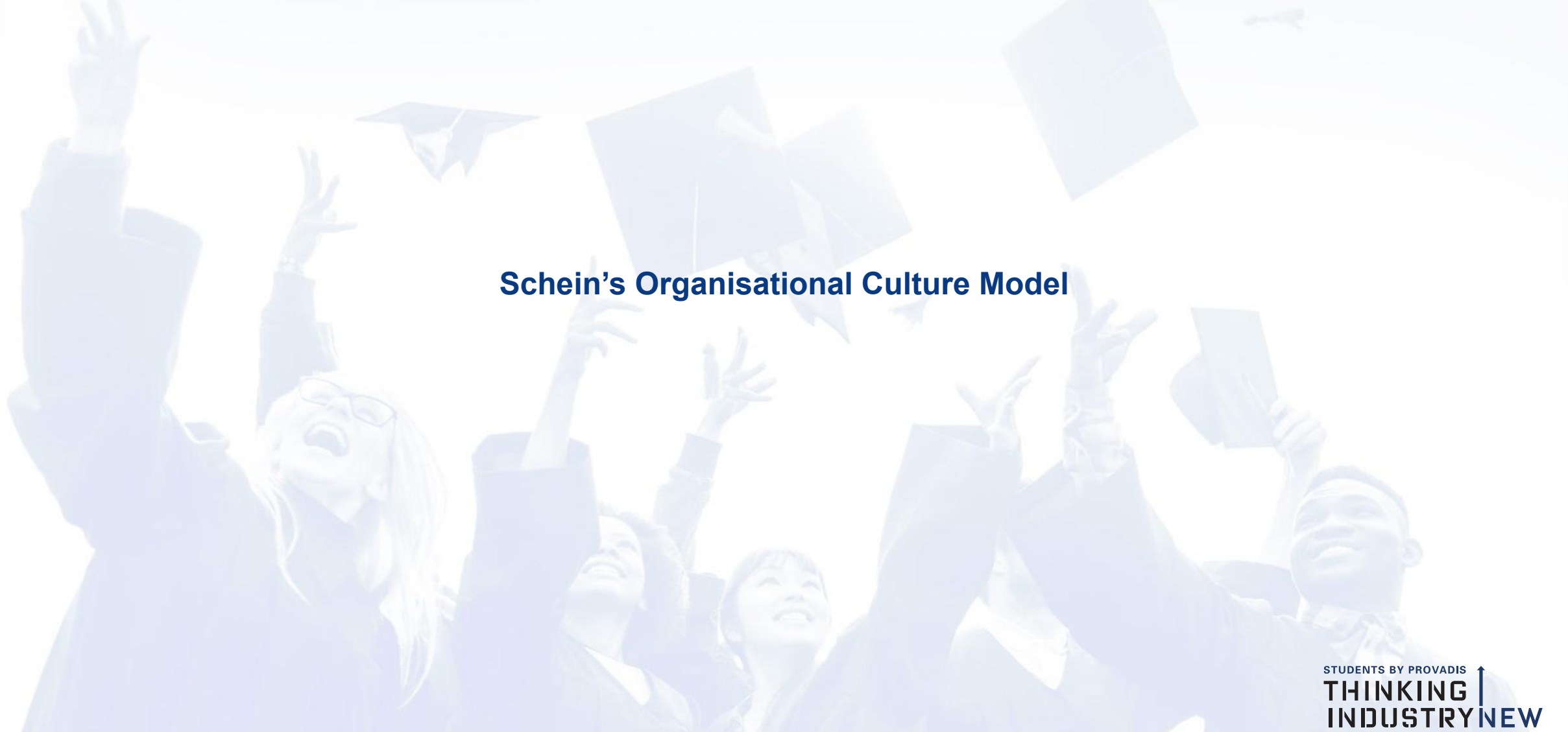
Remember:

Cultural differences are **not right or wrong**

They are **different ways** of working

If your friend/colleague **breaks a rule**, would you **tolerate** them or **reject/report** them?

Which **dimension** do you **relate** to **most**—and why?

A low-angle, blue-tinted photograph of a group of graduates in black gowns. They are all looking upwards with expressions of joy and excitement, and several black graduation caps are captured mid-air, having been tossed by the graduates. The background is a bright, clear sky.

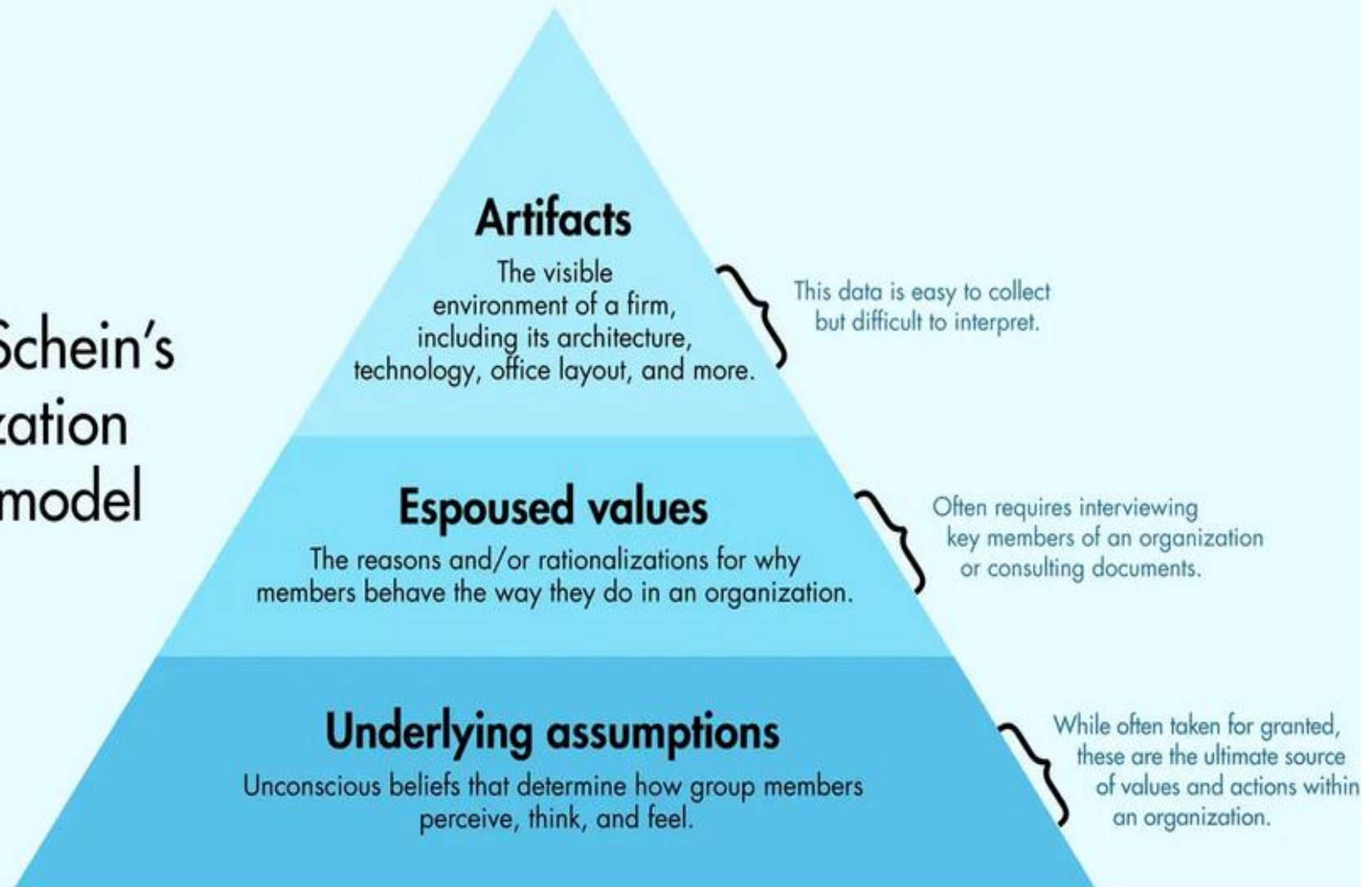
Schein's Organisational Culture Model

The Three Levels

1. Artifacts (Visible)

- Dress code
- Office layout
- Language, rituals

Edgar Schein's organization culture model



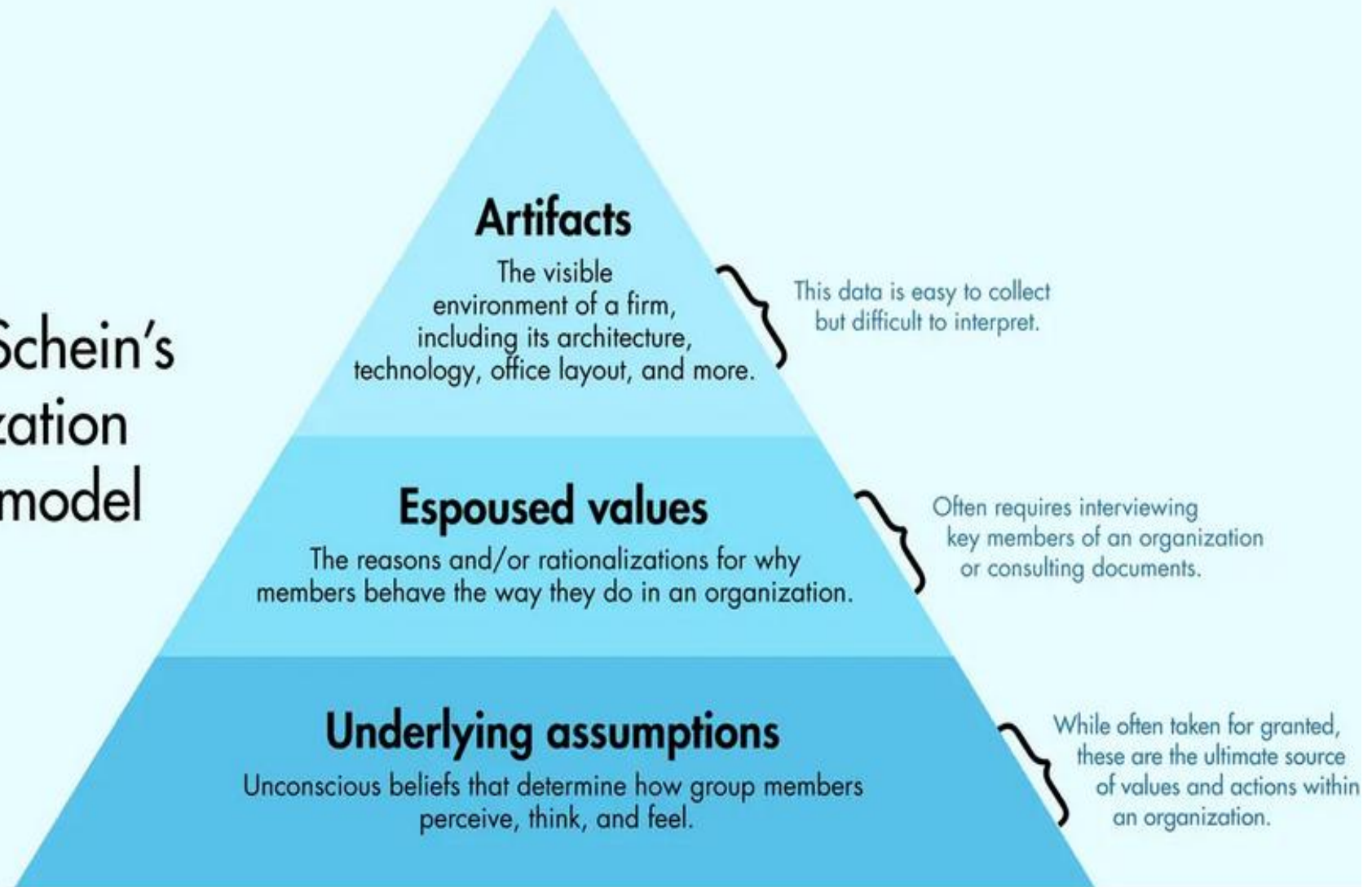
<https://mitsloan.mit.edu/ideas-made-to-matter/5-enduring-management-ideas-mit-sloans-edgar-schein>

The Three Levels

2. Values (Stated)

- Company mission
- “We value teamwork”
- Official rules

Edgar Schein's organization culture model



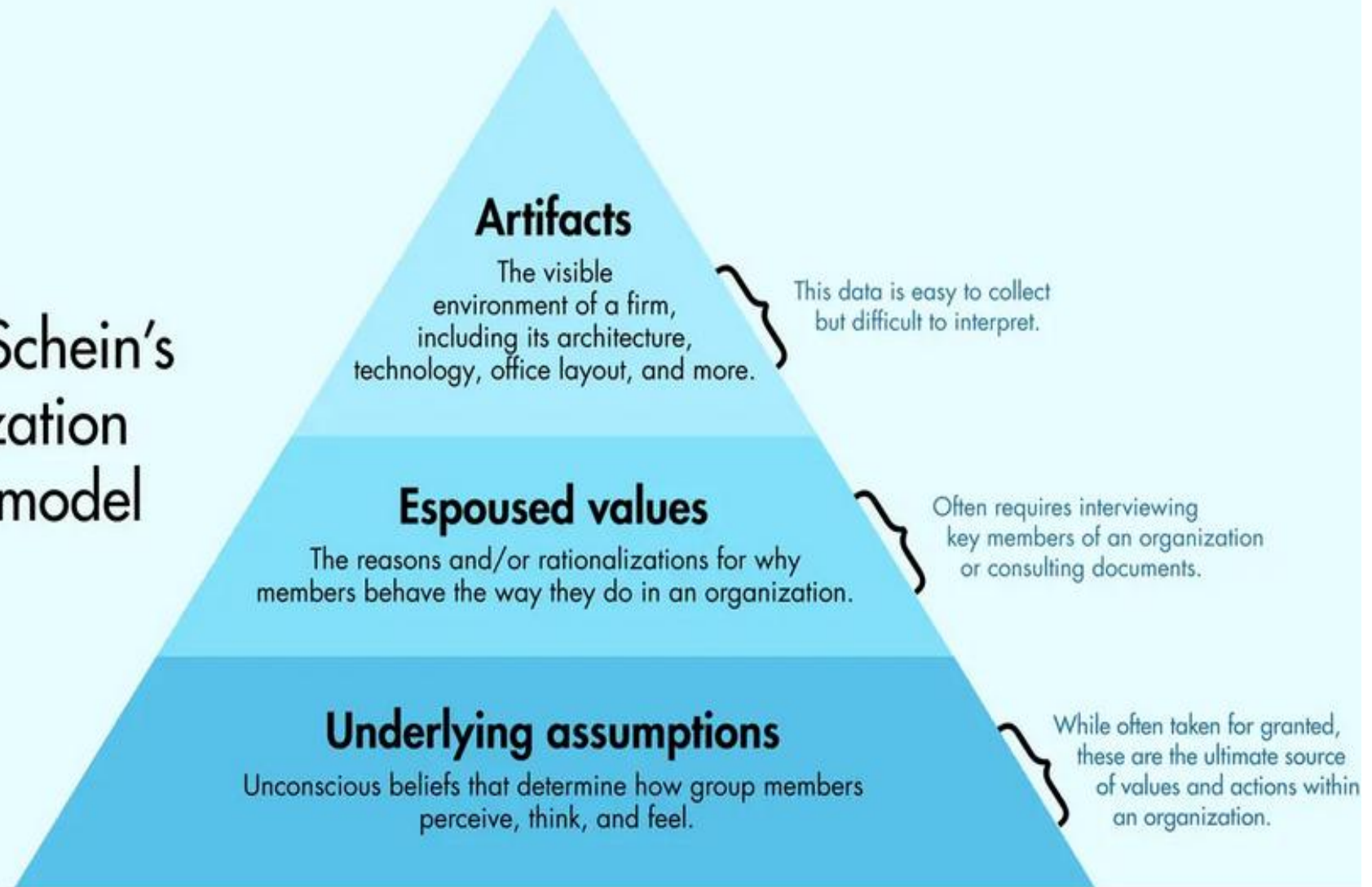
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The Three Levels

3, Assumptions (Hidden)

- Unconscious beliefs
- “How things really work”
- Taken for granted

Edgar Schein's organization culture model



<https://mitsloan.mit.edu/ideas-made-to-matter/5-enduring-management-ideas-mit-sloans-edgar-schein>

Insight:

Culture becomes less **visible** but more **powerful** at deeper levels

What do you **see first** when joining a new company?

The Hidden Level: Assumptions Drive Behaviour

Why **Assumptions** Matter?
Very Important!

Most cultural **problems** happen at the **assumption level**

Example

Level	What is visible	What really drives behaviour
Artifacts	Open office space	"We <i>collaborate</i> "
Values	"We <i>encourage</i> feedback"	People avoid criticism
Assumptions	Invisible ×	" Criticism is risky "

Insight: **People often:**
Say one thing (values)
But may act **differently (assumptions)**

Key Learning Lessons

Schein's Organisational Culture Model

You **cannot** understand a **culture** by looking only at:

- posters
- policies
- mission statements

→ You must understand **hidden beliefs/assumptions**

Have you ever experienced a **working environment** saying **one** thing but doing **another**? Example?

Applying Schein in Intercultural Teams

Application: Culture in Intercultural Teams

Situation	Universalism	Particularism
Deadlines	Must always be respected	Flexible if relationship matters
Contracts	Strict, formal	Can adapt based on trust

Meetings	Calm, controlled	Expressive, animated
Feedback	Formal, structured	Direct, emotional

Most conflicts in teams happen because:
One side expects **rules**
The other expects **relationships**

Situation:

An international team **struggles** with **feedback**



Result:

- **Misunderstandings**
- Perceived **rudeness** or **silence**

Analysis using Schein

• Artifacts:

Open discussions in meetings

• Values:

“We value transparency”

• Assumptions:

- Culture A → **direct** feedback is normal
- Culture B → feedback should be **indirect**
- Culture C → **avoid conflict**

Solution

To manage cultural differences:

- Ask about **expectations**
- Make **implicit** rules **explicit**
- Build **psychological** safety

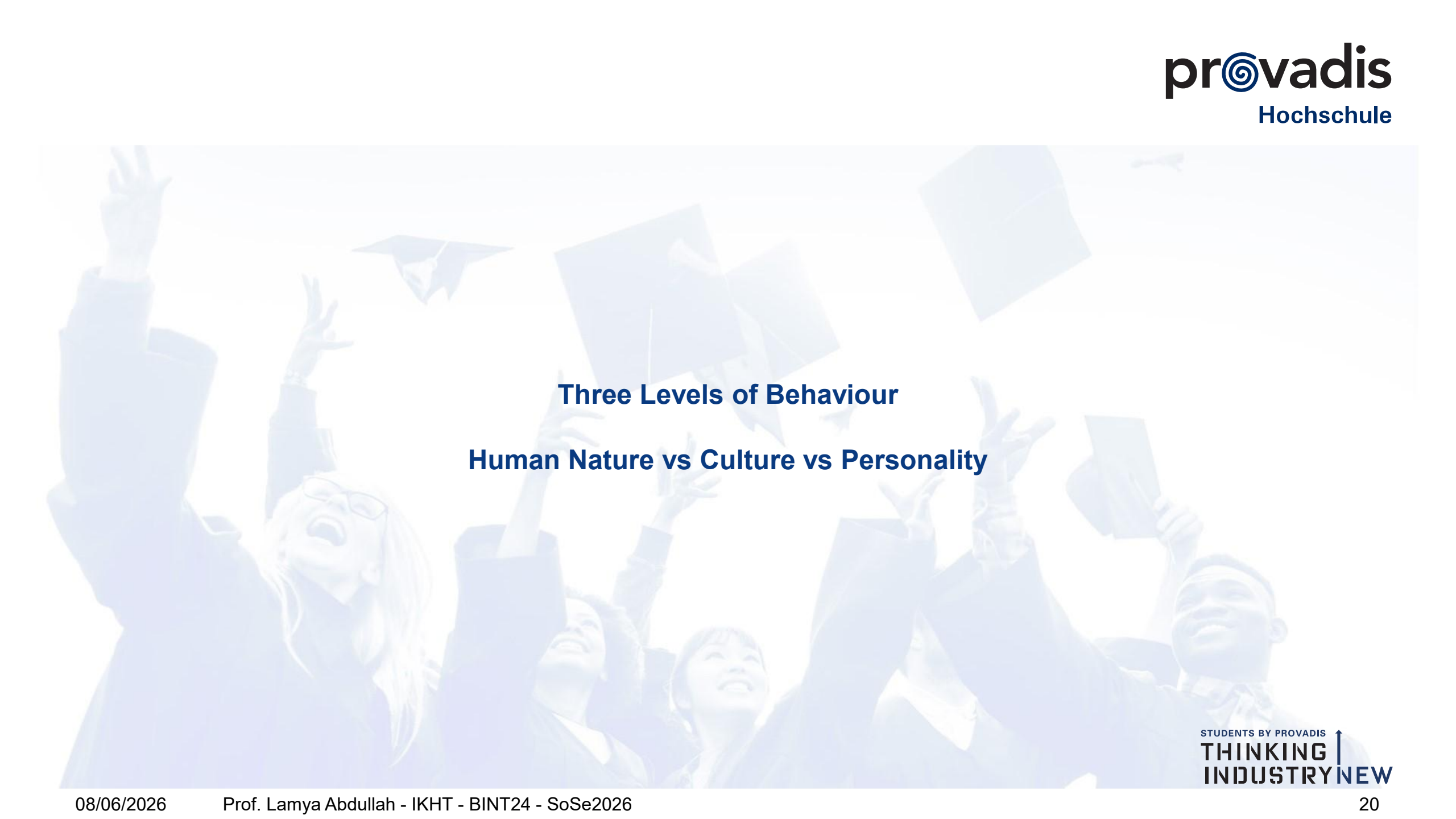
Final Key insight

→ **Successful** teams:

- **Surface hidden assumptions**
- **Do not assume** shared understanding

Reflection:

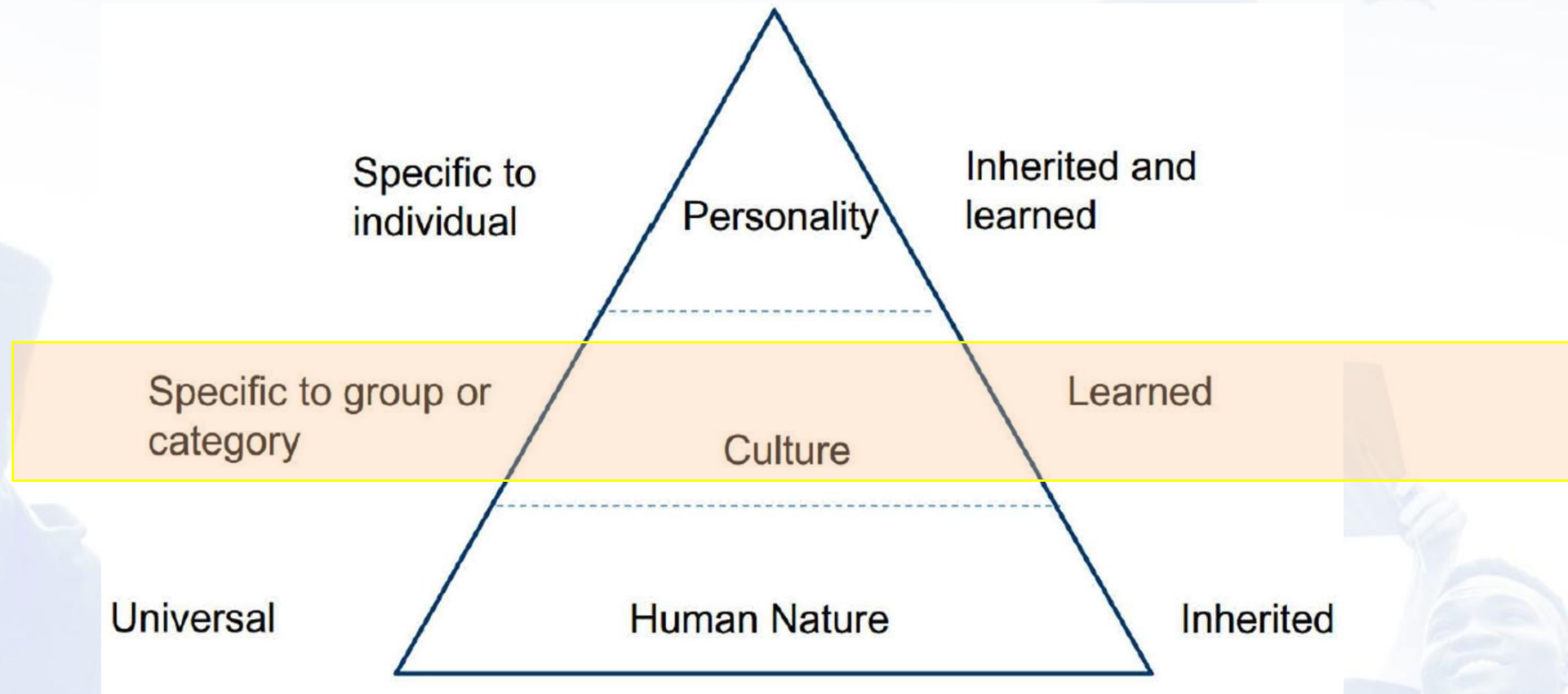
Which **level** do you **usually** notice first—and which do you ignore?"

A low-angle, blue-tinted photograph of a group of graduates in black gowns, cheering and throwing their mortarboards into the air. The scene is filled with joy and celebration, with several caps captured mid-air against a bright, overexposed background.

Three Levels of Behaviour

Human Nature vs Culture vs Personality

Hierarchy of Human Behavior



Behaviour: How human nature, culture, and personality interact

Human Nature

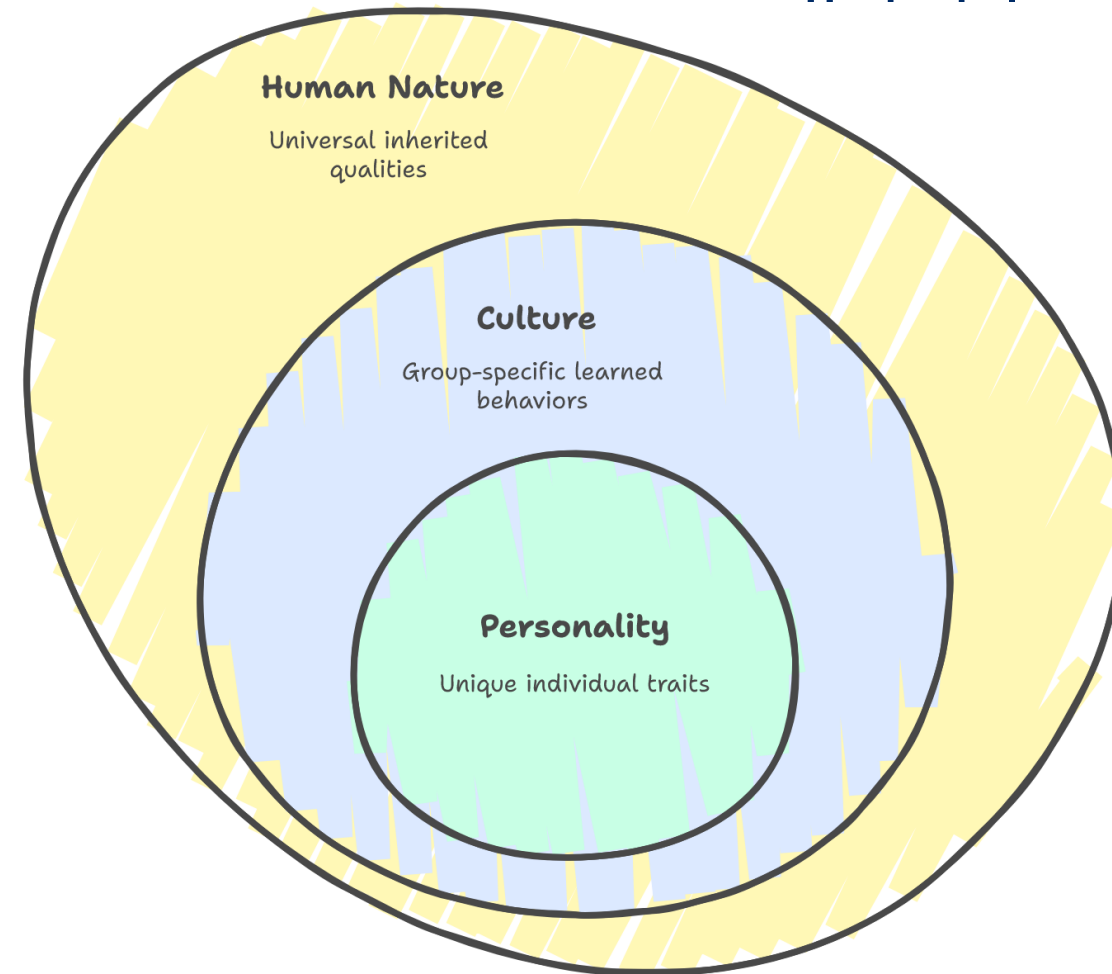
- Universal (all human) and inherited
- **Basic instincts and needs shared by all human**
- **Examples:** hunger, fear of failure, desire to belong, anger, etc

Culture

- Learned and group-specific
- **Influences norms**, values, behaviours, language
- **Examples:** Time orientation, Communication styles (direct vs. indirect), Attitudes toward hierarchy, etc...

Personality

- **Individual differences**
- Formed through a **mix** of inherited traits and learned experiences
- Explains variation within the same culture
- Example: Introvert / extrovert



Behaviour is NOT only culture. It is a combination
of:

human nature

culture

personality

Reflection:

If someone is **quiet**, is it **culture**—or **personality**?

Understanding Behaviour in Diverse Teams

Why This Matters in Teams?

Common Mistake

→ People often **misinterpret** behaviour

Practical Example

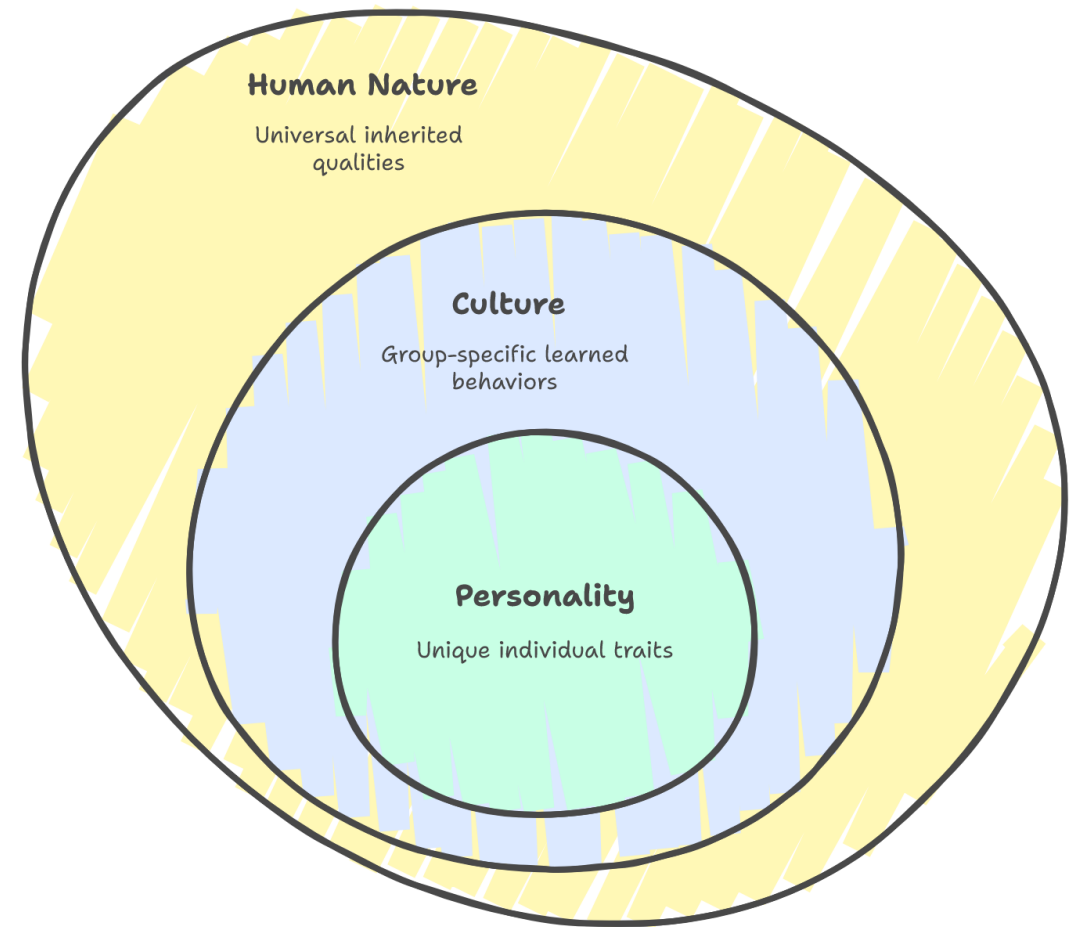
Situation: A team member never speaks in meetings

Key Insight
The **SAME** behaviour can have **different** causes

Explanation	Interpretation
Personality	Introverted
Culture	Respect for hierarchy
Human Nature	Fear of being judged

Why This Matters in Teams?

- Builds cultural **self-awareness** and team **empathy**
- **Reduces** misunderstandings and conflict
- Enhances trust, inclusion, and productivity
- **Supports** effective communication and leadership in diverse teams



Learning Lessons:

- Wrong assumption → **Conflict**
- Correct understanding → **Collaboration**

Reflection:

Have you ever **misunderstood** someone's **behaviour**?

From Assumptions to Understanding

Application: How to Avoid Misunderstanding

What people often do ✖

- Jump to **conclusions**
- Judge behaviour **quickly**
- Assume “**this is cultural**”

What you should do instead ✔

1. Observe **behaviour**
2. **Ask** questions
3. **Consider** all **three levels**:
 - Human nature
 - Culture
 - Personality

Practical Tool (your ToolKit)



Before **judging** behaviour, ask yourself:

- Is this about **culture**?
- Or **personality**?
- Or a **human reaction** (stress, fear, pressure)?

Final Insight:

Good intercultural **competence** means:

NOT over-attributing everything to culture

Everything different **≠** Cultural difference

Not all behaviour is **culture** → sometimes it's **personality**

Reflection:

What behaviour have you **wrongly attributed to culture** before?

A low-angle, blue-tinted photograph of a diverse group of graduates in black gowns. They are all looking upwards with expressions of joy and excitement, their arms raised high. Several black graduation caps are captured mid-air, having just been tossed. The background is a bright, clear sky.

Cultural Sensitivity

Cultural Sensitivity:

As a Foundation for Intercultural Teams

Cultural sensitivity = the **ability** to recognise differences and **adapt** behaviour accordingly.

What is it?

Awareness of and Respect for cultural differences, **avoiding assumptions** or judgments.
Adapting your approach to diverse norms and values.

Prevents **misunderstandings**
Builds **trust**
Enables **effective teamwork**

Is understanding **enough** ... or do we need **adaptation**?

Cultural Sensitivity:

As a Foundation for Intercultural Teams

Cultural sensitivity = the **ability** to recognise differences and **adapt** behaviour accordingly.

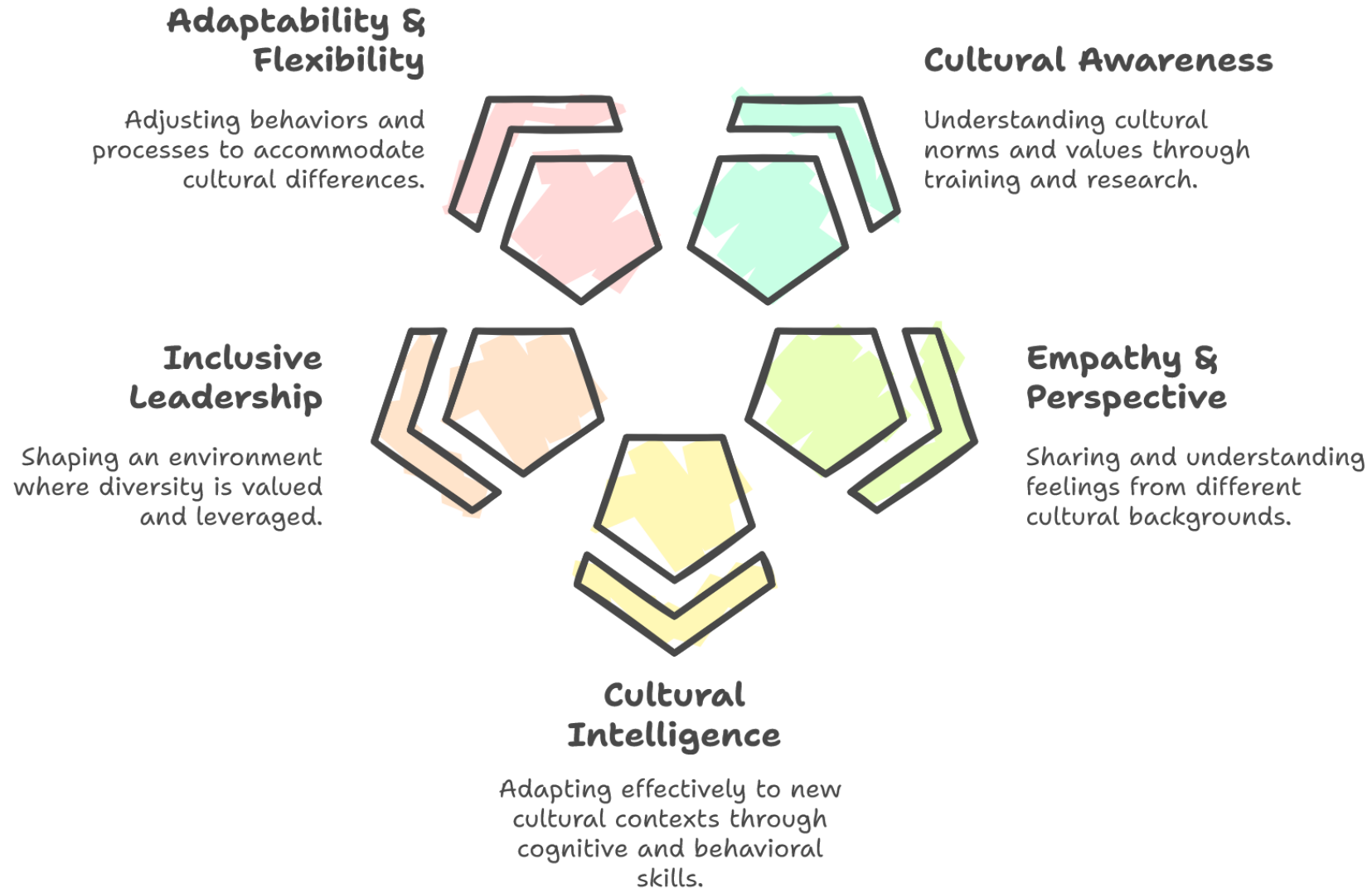
Why it Matters?

Crucial for **effective teamwork**, innovation, and **conflict resolution** in heterogeneous teams.

- Improved Communication: Bridging diverse communication styles (e.g., direct/indirect, high/low-context).
- Enhanced Collaboration: Building trust and valuing diverse perspectives.
- Increased Innovation: Tapping into a wider range of ideas and problem-solving approaches.
- Reduced Conflict: Preventing misunderstandings rooted in cultural differences.

Prevents **misunderstandings**
Builds **trust**
Enables **effective teamwork**

Building Cultural Sensitivity: Key Approaches



1. Cultural Awareness & Knowledge:

- **Focus:** Understanding specific cultural norms, values, communication styles (e.g., Hofstede's Dimensions).
- **How:** Cultural **training**, information **sharing**, **individual research**.

2. Empathy & Perspective-Taking:

- **Focus:** Ability to understand and share others' feelings from different cultural backgrounds.
- **How:** **Active listening**, asking **clarifying** questions, promoting **open** dialogue.

3. Cultural Intelligence (CQ):

- **Focus:** Capability to adapt effectively to new cultural contexts. Covers Cognitive (knowledge), Motivational (drive), Behavioural (action), and Metacognitive (strategy) aspects.
- **How:** Self-assessment, targeted CQ training, diverse experiences.

4. Inclusive Leadership & Team Norms:

- **Focus:** Leaders and team actively shaping an inclusive environment where diversity is leveraged.
- **How:** Setting clear expectations, fostering psychological safety, celebrating diversity, addressing biases.

5. Adaptability & Flexibility (**Very Important**):

- **Focus:** Willingness and ability to adjust behaviours, expectations, and processes to accommodate differences.
- **How:** **Flexible work arrangements**, adapting **communication**, openness to new approaches.

→ **Knowing is not enough** → you must **adapt** your behaviour

Which is **hardest**: awareness, empathy, or adaptation?

From Cultural Awareness to Effective Behaviour

From Knowledge to **Action**

What people often do ✖

- Assume others think like them
- Judge behaviour
- Blame “culture”

What effective professionals do ✔

- Observe
- Ask
- Adapt

From Cultural Awareness to Effective Behaviour

From Knowledge to **Action**

Practical Example

Situation: Feedback in a team

- Culture A → **direct** feedback
- Culture B → **indirect** feedback

Without sensitivity: ✖

- “They are **rude**”
- “They are **unclear**”

With cultural sensitivity: ✔

- “They have **different communication norms**”

Cultural sensitivity = **understanding + behaviour change**

Reflection:

When was the last time you adapted your behaviour in a team? Example?

Related resource

Talks

- **Riding the waves of culture: Fons Trompenaars**
<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=hmyfjKjcbm0>

- **How Culture Drives Behaviours**
<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=l-Yy6poJ2zs>



The Concept of Cultural Intelligence
<https://www.mindtools.com/aisl5uv/cultural-intelligence?from=search>

Cultural Intelligence Tests and Survey - free
<https://georginabarquin.com/cultural-intelligence-free-tests/>



The Cultural Intelligence Center (CQC)
<https://culturalq.com/>

Discussion – for each team – 5-10 mins

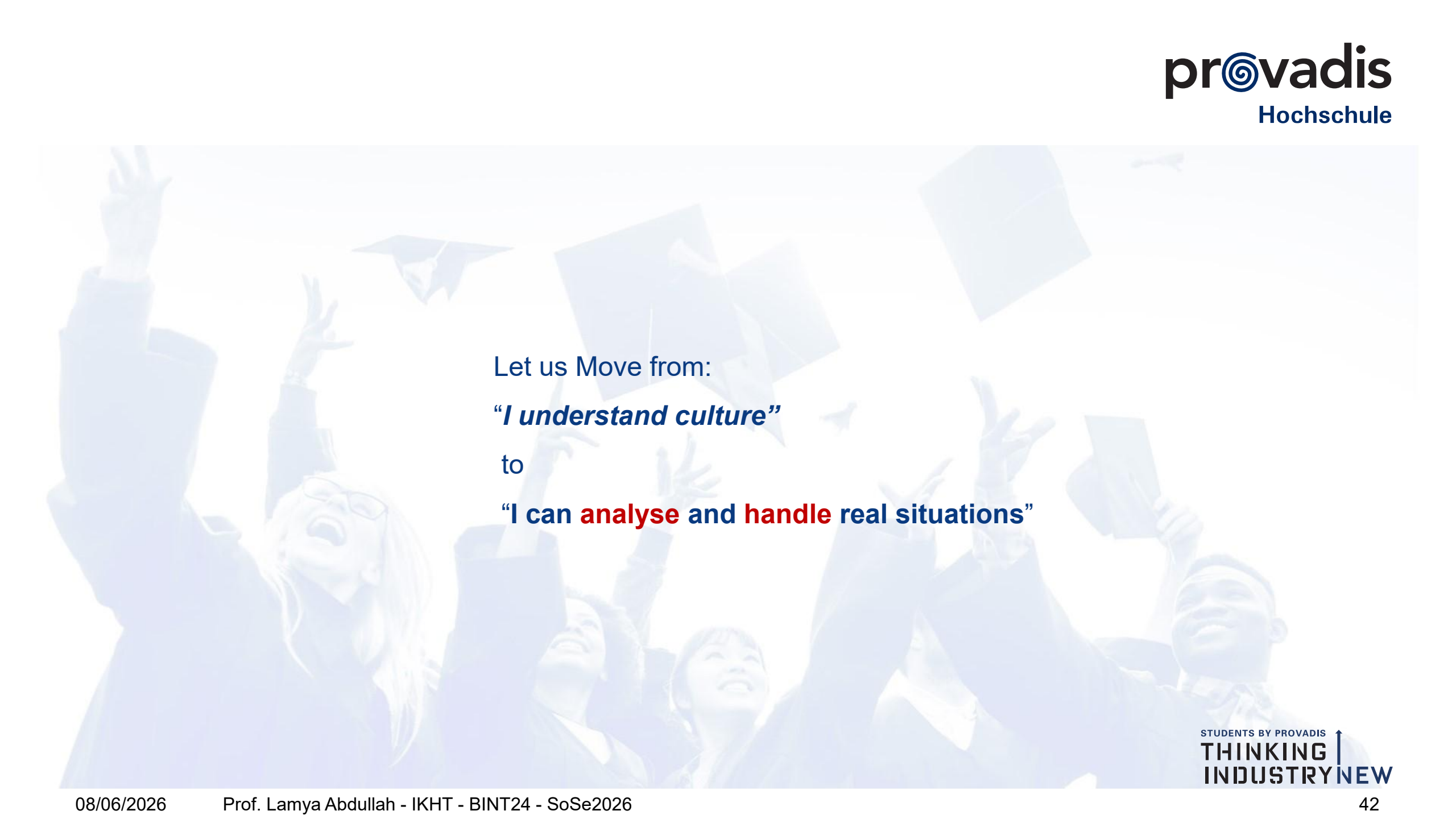


Think about a time when a **misunderstanding** in a group project was due to cultural differences.

- What **happened**?
- What cultural **factors** were involved? If any.
- How was it **resolved**?



Breakout rooms

A blue-tinted background image showing a group of graduates in gowns and caps, celebrating with their arms raised and caps tossed into the air.

Let us Move from:
“I understand culture”
to
“I can analyse and handle real situations”

Real case example



- Conflict between **junior** + **senior** employee
- **Hierarchy** + **expectations** create tension
- What is **cultural**?
- What is **personality**?

Case Study: When Culture Meets Reality

Structured Analysis: How to Analyse the Situation?



1. Identify Behaviour

- Who is doing what?

2. Apply Models

- **Hofstede**
(e.g., individualism, power distance)
- **Trompenaars**
(rules vs relationships, emotional vs neutral)
- **Schein**
→ what are the hidden assumptions?

3. Analyse Causes

Is **behaviour** caused by:

- Culture?
- Personality?
- Human nature (fear, pressure)?

Do NOT jump to conclusions ... analyse before judging!

Case Study: When Culture Meets Reality



Scenario : *A multicultural team is working on a project.*

- One team member gives **direct feedback**
- Another avoids criticism and stays **silent**
- A third member becomes **frustrated** with the lack of clarity

The team starts experiencing:

- Miscommunication
- Frustration
- Reduced collaboration

Task (15 mins)

Analyse the situation using what you learned:

1. Which **cultural differences** might be involved?
2. Which **models** can explain this?
3. What is the **main** problem?
4. What cultural **differences** are involved?
5. What **assumptions** might **exist** (Schein)?
6. **How** would you **solve** the situation?

Prepare to share your analysis with the class!

- Each group should at least, Give **1 explanation** and Suggest **1 solution**

- **Same** behaviour → **different** interpretations
- **Culture** influences **communication** styles
- **Assumptions** (Schein) are **often** hidden
- **Misunderstanding** ≠ bad intention

Critical Takeaway

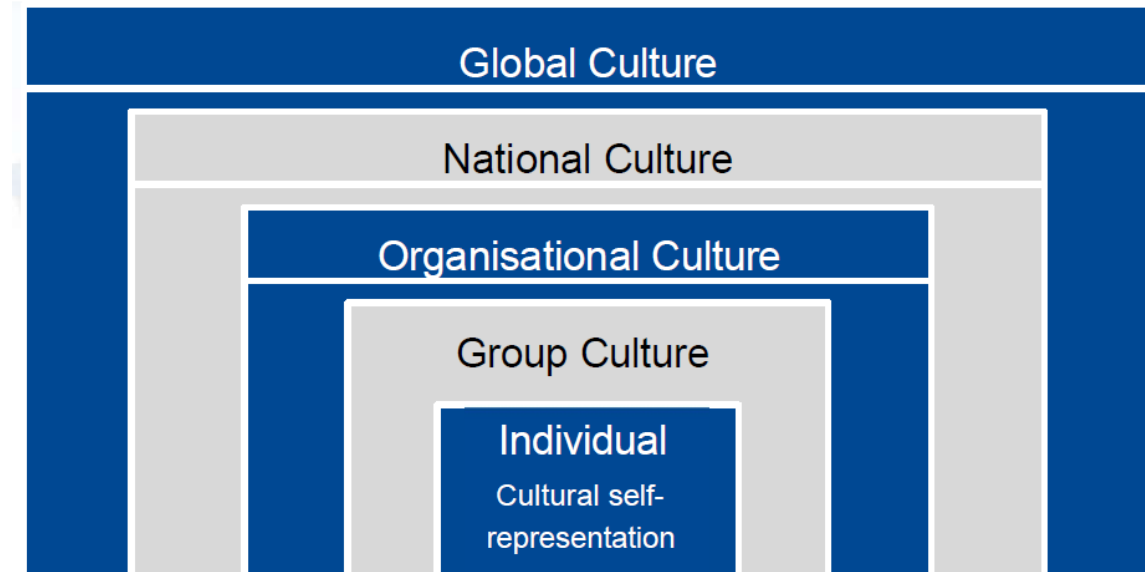
The problem is **NOT** culture itself

The problem is: **how we interpret differences**

A low-angle, blue-tinted photograph of several graduates in black gowns, cheering and throwing their mortarboards into the air. The scene is filled with a sense of triumph and accomplishment.

Culture for Business
Organizational level

- **Individual decision making** process is **influenced** by **different layers** of culture
- These layers are **nested into each other**, constituting a **system of interrelated cultural aspects** of different cultural layers
- Culture is an **outcome** of past (and present) actions of a group -> result of a group's actions and the **origin** of its actions at the same time
- Culture -> a group of people that share a **common set of values and norms** and characterised by being **learned, shared and interrelated**
- Culture is **reinforced** by its **components** such as language, behaviour, ...



Why This Matters in Teams?

Several **managerial** tasks in **international** business where **cross-cultural proficiency** is important:

- Communicating and interacting with **foreign business partners**
- **Screening** and **selecting** foreign distributors and other **partners**
- **Negotiating** and structuring **international** business **ventures** or international alliances
- **Interacting** with **customers** from **abroad**
- Dealing with **national institutions** in **host** countries
- Developing **products** and services
- Preparing **advertising** and **promotional** materials

Connecting the Dots:

- **Organizational Culture:** The "**personality**" of a **company** – its shared values, beliefs, and practices.
- **Impact:** Significantly influences how cultural sensitivity is perceived, developed, and practiced internally and externally.
- **Key Idea:** Different **organizational types** **foster** or **hinder** cultural sensitivity in distinct ways.

Diversity in Organization =

"All differences that influence how people think, act, and work."

Common Organizational Culture Types & Their Impact

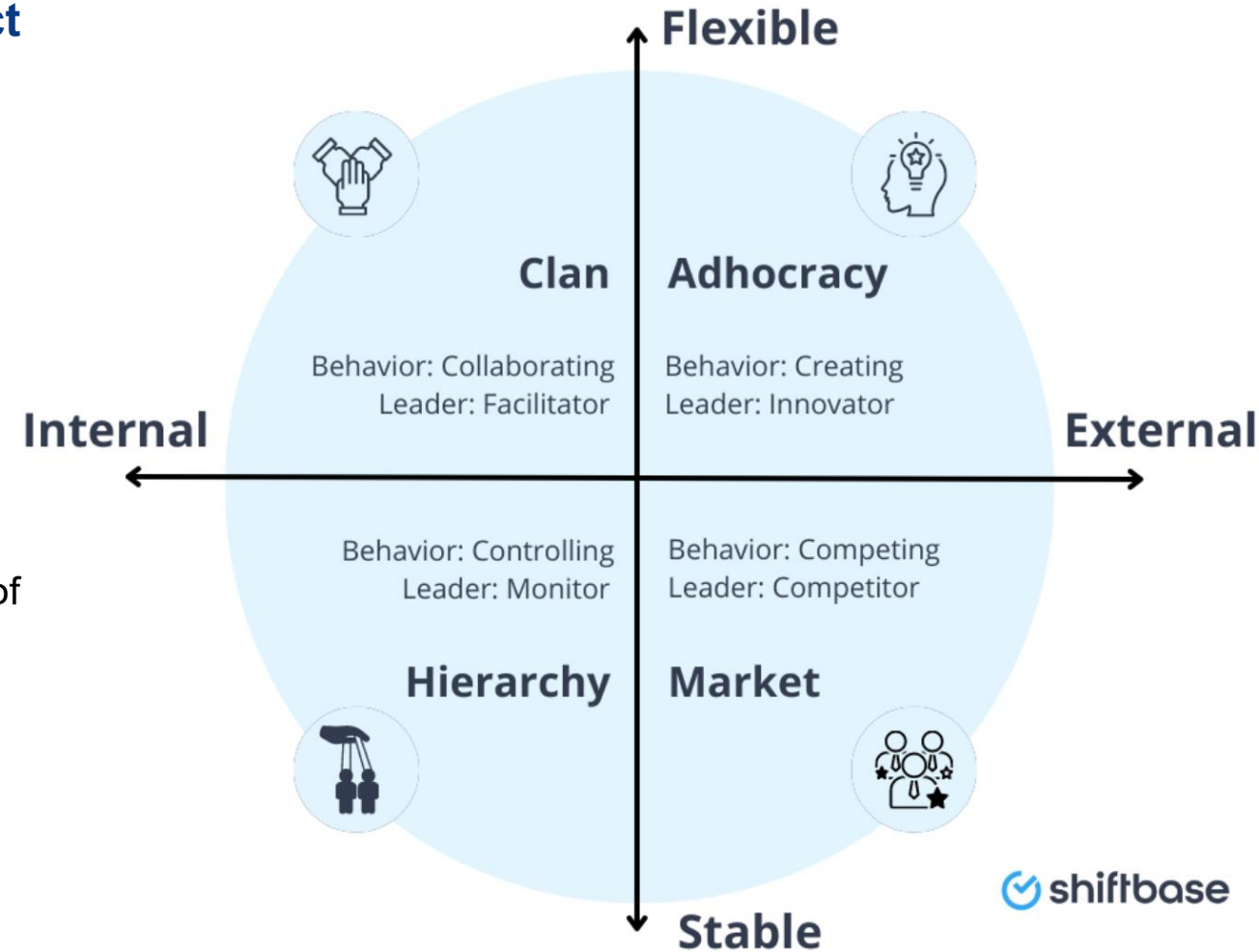
Competing Values Framework (CVF)

1. Clan Culture (Collaborate / Family):

- **Characteristics:** People-oriented, friendly, collaborative, strong teamwork.
- **Impact on Cultural Sensitivity:** High Potential. Naturally fosters empathy and open communication.
- **Challenge:** Can become **isolated** if not proactively inclusive of all backgrounds.

2. Adhocracy Culture (Create / Dynamic):

- **Characteristics:** Innovative, flexible, risk-taking, focused on creativity.
- **Impact on Cultural Sensitivity:** Mixed Potential. Values diverse ideas.
- **Challenge:** Fast pace can sometimes overshadow deliberate cultural understanding; implicit **pressure** to **"fit in"** quickly.



<https://www.shiftbase.com/glossary/company-culture-types>

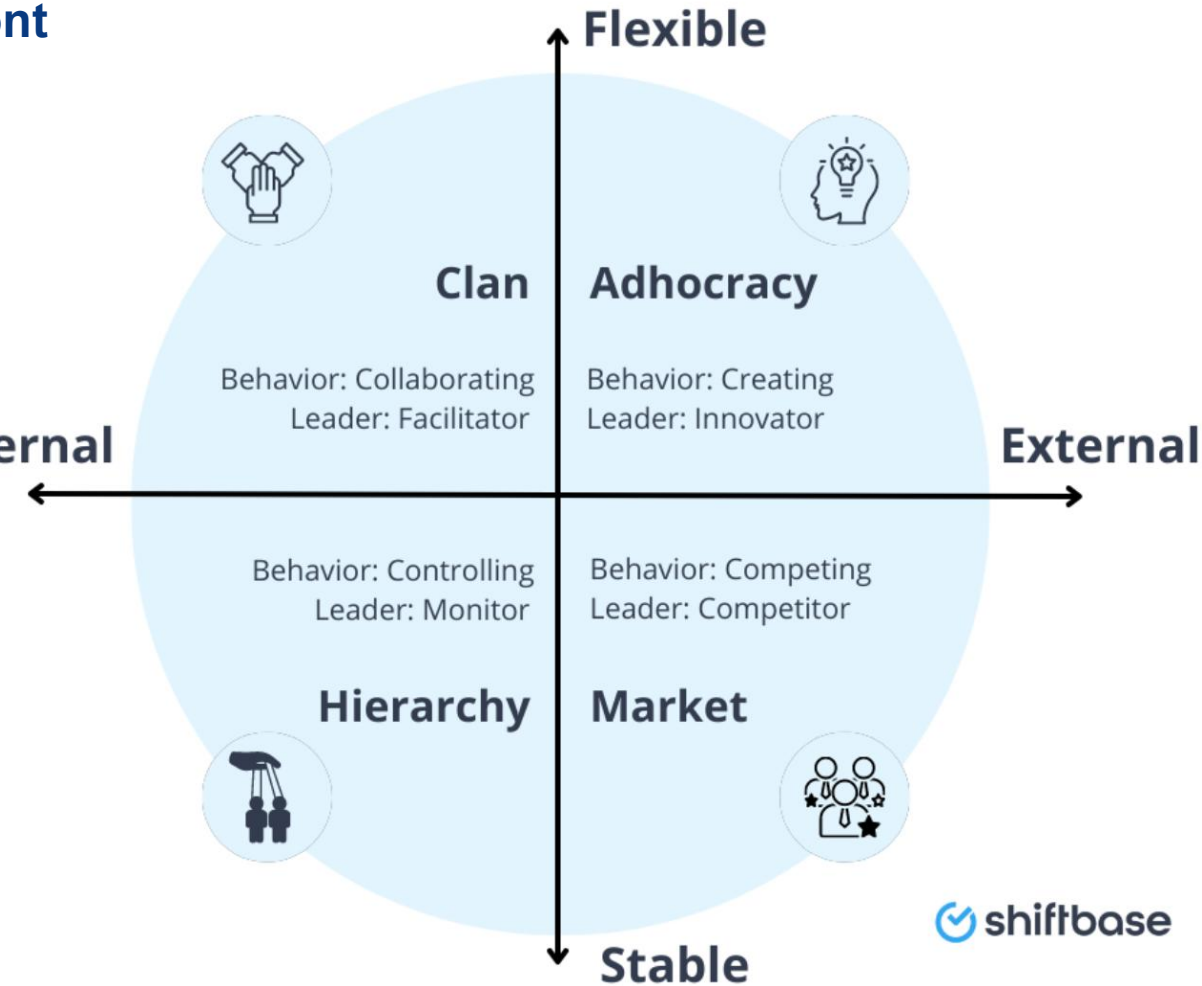
Common Organizational Culture Types & Their Impact, cont

3. Market Culture (Compete / Results-Oriented):

- **Characteristics:** Results-driven, competitive, focused on profitability and goals.
- **Impact on Cultural Sensitivity:** Lower Natural Tendency. Less inherent focus beyond direct business impact.
- **Challenge:** "Sink or swim" mentality; cultural differences may be seen as obstacles to efficiency unless strategically valued.

4. Hierarchy Culture (Control / Structured):

- **Characteristics:** Process-oriented, stable, controlled, clear roles/rules, efficiency-focused.
- **Impact on Cultural Sensitivity:** Formal but Potentially Rigid. Fairness through rules; often invests in formal training.
- **Challenge:** Rigidity can stifle individual expression; bureaucracy may **hinder quick response** to cultural nuances.

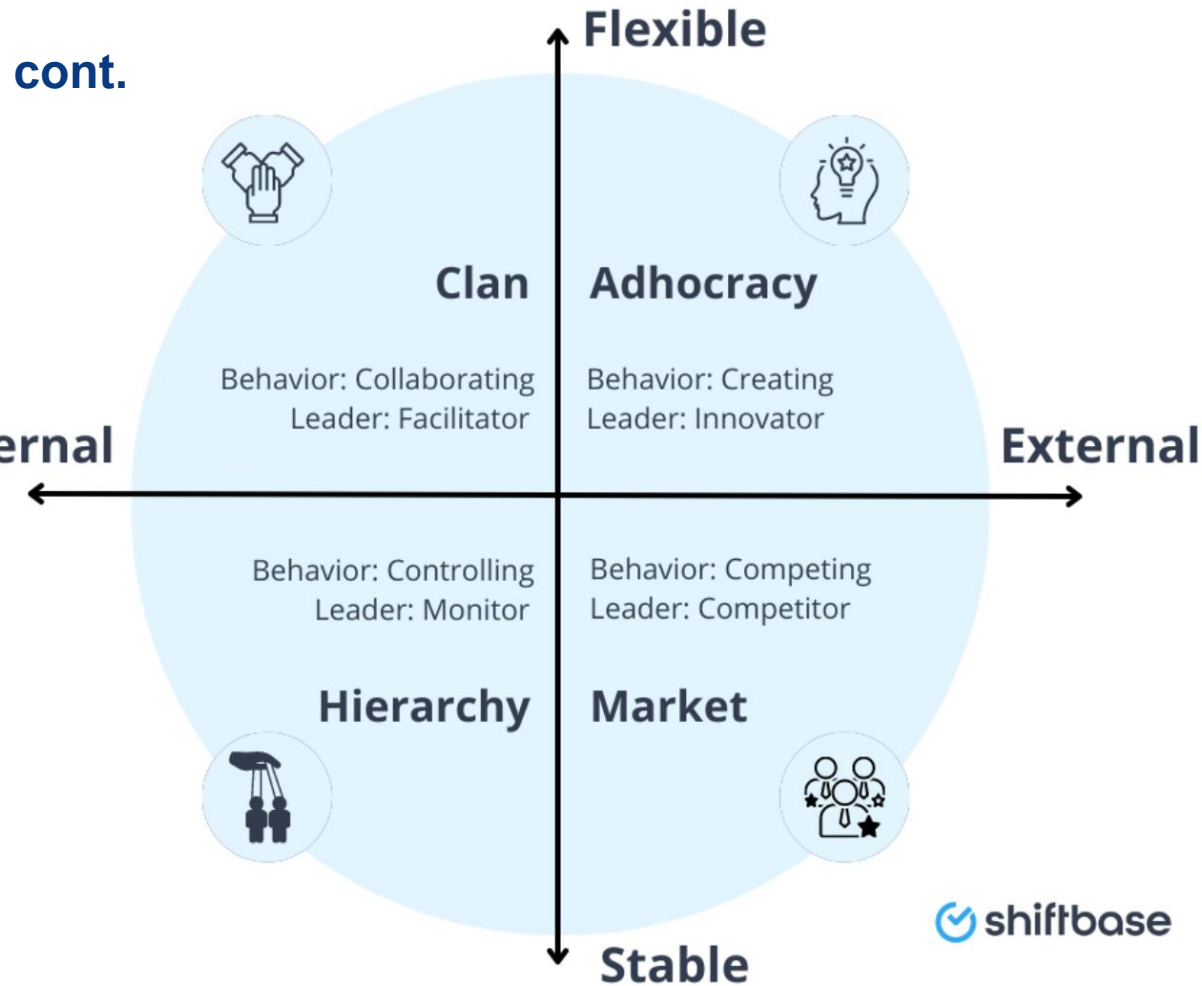


<https://www.shiftbase.com/glossary/company-culture-types>

Common Organizational Culture Types & Their Impact, cont.

Key Takeaways for All Organizations:

- **Leadership is Crucial:** Leaders must model and champion cultural sensitivity.
- **Proactive D&I:** Implement **Diversity & Inclusion** initiatives (training, policies).
- **Psychological Safety:** Create an environment where all feel safe to voice cultural needs.
- **Adaptation over Assimilation:** Promote mutual learning, not just fitting in.



<https://www.shiftbase.com/glossary/company-culture-types>

Some cultures support diversity **better** than others

Group Challenge: Organisational Culture in a Global Team [15 min]



Goal 💡

Understand how culture shapes behaviour, decisions, and communication

Scenario: *Your team is launching a global virtual product.*

Team members come from **Germany, Brazil, South Korea, and the US.**

- There is **high pressure to meet deadlines**
- But also a need for **innovation and inclusion**

Group Assignment:

Each group represents **ONE organisational culture type:**

- Clan (collaborative, people-focused)
- Adhocracy (innovative, flexible)
- Market (results-driven, competitive)
- Hierarchy (structured, controlled)

Group Rule:

Your group = (Group number mod 4) + 1

Prepare Your Team Output

→ Each group prepares at least:

1 Key Insight (main learning), **1 Risk** (biggest challenge), and **1 Solution** (how to improve collaboration)

Structured Analysis

1. Approach to the Project

- How would your **culture organise** the work?
- What would be **prioritised**?
(speed, structure, innovation, relationships)

2. Strengths in Diverse Teams

- What **advantages** does your culture bring?
- How does it **support performance** or **collaboration**?

3. Potential Challenges

- Where could **conflicts arise** with other **cultures**?
- What **behaviours** might be **misunderstood**?

4. Communication Strategies (MOST IMPORTANT)

- How should **communication** be adapted?
- What would **help collaboration** across cultures?

Think practically - what would you actually DO as a team?



Reflection:
Which culture would YOU **prefer** to work in, and **why**?

What Did We Learn?

- Which culture focused on **people**?
- Which focused on **results**?
- Which focused on **structure**?
- Which focused on **innovation**?

Key Learned lessons:

Different organisational cultures:

- prioritise different goals
- create different behaviours

In diverse teams:

- same situation → different approaches

Critical Insight

The challenge is **NOT** diversity itself

The challenge is **aligning expectations**